Read this first

If you are in the middle of this counselling cycle, you have roughly a week before the next window opens. So here is the whole book in one page.

The short version

You are juggling four separate doors - 50% All India Quota, your state's 50%, 100% deemed universities and 100% DNB - and every one of them runs on the same four-round calendar published by MCC.

In 2026 the one big new rule is Freeze and Float. Freeze means you join physically and stop. Float means you stay in the upgrade race without ever visiting the college.

Round 1 is a free exit. Round 2 is not. Leave a Round 2 seat and your security deposit is gone - Rs 25,000 on AIQ, Rs 2,00,000 on deemed.

Nobody can resign a Round 3 seat. If you take it, you keep it.

The seat you are allotted is provisional until the college physically checks your originals. Wrong or missing papers cancel a seat that was already yours.

Choice order is the only real power you have. Merit decides who is asked; your list decides what you are asked for.

Read Part 3, Part 4 and Part 6 before your next choice-filling window. Those three decide whether you end up with a seat you want or a deposit you have lost. Everything else is reference - the calendar, the document list, the bond questions, the worksheets - and you will come back to it on the day.

Part 13 has the worksheets you can print and fill: a choice-order planner, a decision matrix for comparing two allotments, a bond-and-cost sheet and a 30-day action plan.

It is not a rank predictor and it is not a substitute for the official bulletin. Cut-offs move every year with the seat matrix, and no honest guide can tell you that 12,000 will get you radiology in a particular college. What it can do is make sure you never lose a seat to a missed rule, a wrong document or a badly ordered list - which is how most seats are actually lost.

Where every fact comes from

The Medical Counselling Committee's NEET-PG Counselling 2026 Information Bulletin and Counselling Scheme; MCC's AIQ and State Counselling Schedule for PG 2026 dated 8 October 2026; the NBEMS notice declaring NEET-PG 2026 results on 24 September 2026; the AIIMS INI-CET January 2027 prospectus (Part A); and state counselling notices quoted where a state is named. Figures are as published in October 2026. MCC revises schedules at short notice - so treat this book as your map and mcc.nic.in as the ground you actually walk on.

deposit at stake for deemed

session begins

One honest warning about money. Every rupee figure in this book is either an MCC fee, an MCC deposit or a figure a state government published. Where a number is disputed between sources, this book says so instead of picking the nicer one. Bond amounts in particular change by government order every single year, and the tables on coaching blogs are frequently two or three years stale.

Every fee, date and rule in this book is taken from the MCC Information Bulletin 2026, the MCC counselling schedule of 8 October 2026, NBEMS result notices and AIIMS INI-CET prospectus.

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How the parts fit together

Parts 1 to 3 are the ground truth: your numbers, the calendar and the money. Parts 4 to 7 are the operational core - what to do after an allotment, what it costs to change your mind, how to build a list, and which later rounds you are still allowed into. Parts 8 to 12 are the decisions that sit behind the list: which door, which bond, which documents, which state, and what to do if the cycle gives you nothing. Part 13 is for printing. Part 14 is for the night before. Part 15 is where you check everything, including anything in this book that has been overtaken by a notice.

A note on how to read the dates

MCC has told every participating institute to treat all Saturdays, Sundays and gazetted holidays as working days for this counselling. So there is no 'it will roll to Monday' cushion this year. A window that closes on a Sunday closes on that Sunday.

PART 1

Where you actually stand

Four doors, one calendar, and a set of numbers that tell you what your rank is really worth.

2,63,544 people wrote this exam. You are competing with all of them, in four different rooms.

NEET-PG 2026 was held on 30 August 2026 and 2,63,544 candidates appeared. Another 2,416 sat a re-examination on 5 September at two Jaipur centres after a power failure stopped their paper. NBEMS declared the result on 24 September 2026, and the qualifying cut-offs it published were these.

Category	Qualifying percentile	Cut-off marks (out of 720)
General / EWS	50th percentile	262
General PwBD	45th percentile	244
SC / ST / OBC, including PwBD of these categories	40th percentile	226

Source: NBEMS result notice of 24 September 2026. Scorecards stay downloadable for six months from issue - download yours to your phone and your email today, because every portal in this process asks for it.

Clearing the cut-off makes you eligible. It does not make a seat likely, and the two numbers that matter after this are your All India Rank and the seat matrix for the round you are in. Neither is fixed: seats get added when NMC approves them, and seats get converted between categories in Round 3.

The four doors, and what sits behind each

MCC conducts counselling for the 50% All India Quota of PG seats (MD, MS, Diploma and post-MBBS DNB) and for 100% of seats in central and deemed universities. Your state conducts its own counselling for the other 50% of state government college seats and for private colleges in the state. Those are two different processes, two different portals, and two different merit lists - and you are allowed to be in both at once, which is the single most valuable thing on this page.

Door	Who runs it	What is in it	Domicile needed?
50% All India Quota	MCC (DGHS, MoHFW)	Half of every state government college's PG seats, plus 50% of BHU and AMU seats and the AIQ share of Delhi University and central institutes	No - domicile free
State quota	Your state's DME / CET Cell	The other 50% of state government seats, and 100% of private (non-deemed) college seats in the state	Usually yes - rules vary
Deemed universities	MCC	100% of seats in deemed universities, including minority and NRI quotas within them	No
DNB (post-MBBS)	MCC for open seats; NBE for in-service	100% of DNB seats, in government and private hospitals	No

Sources: MCC Information Bulletin 2026, Chapter 6 (AIQ), Chapter 7 (Deemed), Chapter 10 (DNB).

The domicile-free list matters more than it looks. The bulletin defines the open, domicile-free seats as: the 50% AIQ seats contributed by states; 50% of BHU seats; 50% of AMU seats; the AIQ seats of Delhi University and central institutes (VMMC and Safdarjung, ABVIMS and RML, ESIC Basaidarapur); 100% of DNB; and 100% of deemed university seats. If you studied in one state and want to work in another, those are the doors open to you.

Reservation inside the All India Quota

The central reservation policy applies to AIQ: SC 15%, ST 7.5%, OBC-Non-Creamy Layer 27%, EWS 10%, and PwD 5% as a horizontal reservation across categories. MCC applies a 3,200-point roster on the 50% AIQ seats. Private DNB institutes have no reservation at all.

Seats convert in Round 3 - and this can rescue you

If an ST(PwD) seat is unfilled after eligible candidates have been considered, it becomes ST. ST becomes SC, SC becomes UR, and EWS becomes UR. PwD seats revert to their own category.

This is why a Round 3 list sometimes shows a UR seat in a college that had none in Round 1. Check the Round 3 seat matrix fresh; do not reuse your Round 1 assumptions.

What your rank does and does not tell you

Your All India Rank is a position in the merit list of everyone who appeared. Counselling uses it for one thing only: to decide when your turn comes. It does not tell you which branch you will get, because that depends on the seat matrix, on the preferences of everyone ranked above you, and on the quota you are competing in. Two candidates with the same rank can end up in very different places because of the lists they wrote.

So write down three numbers and keep them where you can see them while you fill choices.

Number	Where it comes from	What it is used for
All India Rank	NBEMS rank letter	Ordering candidates in MCC's AIQ, deemed and DNB rounds
Category rank	NBEMS category-wise merit	Competing within your reserved category in AIQ
State merit number	Your state's merit list, prepared by the state	Ordering candidates in state quota counselling - this is a different number from your AIR

NBEMS is explicit that the final merit list and the category-wise merit lists for state quota seats are prepared by the states, under their own eligibility criteria and reservation policies. Your state rank can be better or worse than your AIR, which is exactly why registering on both portals is not optional.

Three things you control, and nothing else. How many seats you list; how honestly you order them; and which doors you are registered for. Rank is fixed, the seat matrix is not yours to move, and the preferences of 2.6 lakh other people are entirely outside your hands. Spend your energy on the three things that are not.

PART 2

The only dates that matter

One table, four rounds, two tracks. Screenshot this.

The whole cycle fits on one page - and the state track runs a week behind AIQ

MCC published its combined AIQ and state counselling schedule for PG 2026 on 8 October 2026. Both tracks have Round 1, Round 2, Round 3 and a Stray Vacancy Round. The state track starts and ends roughly a week after the AIQ track, which is what makes it possible to hold an AIQ seat while you try for a state seat.

Round	AIQ / Deemed / Central / DNB window	Join by	State counselling window	Join by
Round 1	12 Oct - 24 Oct 2026	2 Nov 2026	21 Oct - 2 Nov 2026	10 Nov 2026
Round 2	6 Nov - 14 Nov 2026	23 Nov 2026	14 Nov - 23 Nov 2026	30 Nov 2026
Round 3	26 Nov - 4 Dec 2026	12 Dec 2026	4 Dec - 12 Dec 2026	18 Dec 2026
Stray Vacancy	16 Dec - 24 Dec 2026	31 Dec 2026	22 Dec - 25 Dec 2026	31 Dec 2026

Source: MCC, 'NEET-PG Schedule 2026 - All India Quota / Deemed / Central / State Quota', 8 October 2026.

The academic session for PG courses begins on 20 November 2026. That date sits inside Round 2 and it is why the later rounds move so fast. Colleges are already running when Round 3 is allotting seats.

Round 1 in detail, because Round 2 repeats its shape

MCC's tentative schedule for Round 1 breaks the round into six steps. The pattern holds for every later round, so learn it once.

Step	What happens	Round 1 dates
1	Institutes verify the tentative seat matrix	10 - 12 Oct 2026
2	Registration and fee payment	12 - 21 Oct 2026, 12:00 noon (payment till 3:00 pm)
3	Choice filling	13 - 22 Oct 2026, till 10:00 am
4	Choice locking	From 4:00 pm on 21 Oct to 10:00 am on 22 Oct
5	Processing of seat allotment	22 - 23 Oct 2026
6	Result	24 Oct 2026
7	Reporting and joining	26 Oct - 2 Nov 2026

All times are server time. Source: MCC tentative schedule for NEET 50% AIQ and 100% deemed / central universities / AFMS, PG 2026.

Three things about choice locking that catch people out

You do not have to lock manually. The server locks whatever you have saved when the window closes. If you saved nothing, you go into allotment with nothing.

Once locked, choices cannot be edited. Print the locked list - the portal has a 'Print Lock Choice' option - and keep the PDF. It is your only proof of what you asked for.

A provisional result is not a ticket. MCC says plainly: do not book travel on the provisional result, and wait for the final allotment letter.

PART 3

What you pay, and what comes back

Two numbers at registration, one of which you get back - eventually, to the same account.

Registration fee is gone. Security deposit is not - unless you break a rule.

Every candidate pays a non-refundable registration fee plus a refundable security deposit. The deposit is the mechanism that keeps people from blocking seats they will never take, and it is the thing that most people lose by accident rather than by decision.

Payment scheme	Registration fee (non-refundable)	Security deposit (refundable)
AIQ - UR / EWS candidates	Rs 1,000	Rs 25,000
AIQ - SC / ST / OBC / PwD candidates	Rs 500	Rs 10,000
Deemed Universities - all categories	Rs 5,000	Rs 2,00,000

Source: MCC Information Bulletin 2026, FAQ 7 (fees at registration).

If you are applying for both AIQ and deemed universities, you pay the higher figure once - Rs 5,000 plus the Rs 2,00,000 deposit - not both. Worked examples from the bulletin: an SC candidate in AIQ pays Rs 500 plus Rs 10,000; a UR candidate in AIQ pays Rs 1,000 plus Rs 25,000; anyone opting for deemed pays Rs 5,000 plus Rs 2,00,000.

When the deposit is forfeited

MCC forfeits the security deposit in two situations, and both are worth reading twice.

1. You are allotted a seat in Round 2 or any later round - Round 3, stray vacancy, any further round - and you do not report or join at the allotted college to complete admission.
2. Your admission is cancelled after allotment for any reason: wrong information at registration, or failure to produce the required documents at admission within the stipulated time.

Notice what is missing from that list: not joining a Round 1 seat. Round 1 is the one round where walking away is free. That single asymmetry drives almost every sensible strategy in this book.

Getting it back: the refund runs on its own clock

The deposit is refunded only after all rounds of counselling are complete. MCC announces completion on its portal, then HLL Lifecare - the government undertaking that acts as financial custodian for MCC - initiates refunds within 15 days of that notice and completes them within 30 days. The money then takes another 2 to 15 days to land, depending on your bank.

Rule	What it means for you
Refund goes to the same card or account you paid from	Do not pay from a friend's card or a parent's account you cannot keep open
No refund to an NRI account	RBI rules - MCC cannot do it
No interest is paid on the deposit	It is a deposit, not a fixed deposit
Do not raise a chargeback with your bank	It freezes MCC's ability to refund you and can delay it for months
Keep the card or account active until the refund lands	A closed card means a failed refund and a long manual recovery
Refund contact is the financial custodian, not MCC	financemcc@lifecarehll.com for refunds

Source: MCC Information Bulletin 2026, FAQs 51 to 57.

The practical version
Budget as if the deposit is spent until it comes back. A Rs 25,000 AIQ deposit on a card can sit for two to three months after the last round ends - which for this cycle means late December to March. If you are paying with a credit card, know your statement cycle before you pay.

Where the money goes, and when

Three payments happen at three different moments, and confusing them is how people arrive at a college short of funds on joining day.

When	What you pay	Who gets it	Refundable?
At registration	Registration fee (Rs 500, Rs 1,000 or Rs 5,000 depending on scheme and category)	MCC, through its financial custodian	No
At registration	Security deposit (Rs 10,000, Rs 25,000 or Rs 2,00,000)	MCC, through its financial custodian	Yes, after all rounds, subject to the forfeiture rules
At joining	College admission fee, tuition for the year, hostel and bond documents	The allotted college (for DNB, the admission fee is collected by NBE)	Per the college's own refund policy, which MCC does not control
After all rounds	Nothing - you receive the deposit back	You	-

Sources: MCC Information Bulletin 2026, FAQ 7, FAQ 49 and Chapter 10.

Two payment failures worth avoiding. First, only candidates who have paid the full fee become eligible for the further process - a half-completed payment is not a registration. Keep the transaction receipt and the registration number, because the portal's payment status is the only thing that decides whether you are in the round. Second, pay from an account you control and will keep open for months. A deposit paid from a relative's card cannot be refunded to your account, and MCC will not entertain a request to redirect it.

The college's admission fee is a separate negotiation entirely. The bulletin says transaction and service fees charged by a college on upgradation or resignation are between you and the college, and that MCC will not intervene. Ask about them before you join, not after you leave.

PART 4

Freeze and Float: the 2026 change

One new choice after allotment decides whether you keep chasing a better seat or stop.

Until 2025 you had to physically report to upgrade. In 2026 you do not.

This is the biggest procedural change of the cycle and it changes what a Round 1 allotment costs you. In previous years, a candidate who wanted to be considered in Round 2 had to travel to the allotted college with originals, complete admission formalities, and have the college record their willingness to upgrade on MCC's portal. Now MCC splits candidates into two categories immediately after allotment.

	Freeze - no upgrade	Float - wants to upgrade
What it means	You are satisfied with the seat and will not upgrade in the next round	You accept the seat for now but want to be considered for a better one
What you do	Visit the allotted institute physically for joining	Submit willingness online on the MCC portal
Documents	Carry originals to the college; physical verification there	Upload clear scans; the institute's nodal officer verifies online
Do you travel?	Yes	No - online joining, and you generate a provisional confirmation
If you are upgraded later	Not applicable	The earlier seat is cancelled and released; you must join the new one
Risk	None - you are done	If you are upgraded and do not join the new seat, your deposit is forfeited

Source: MCC Information Bulletin 2026, Chapter 3, 'Changes - Allotment, Reporting, Upgradation and Withdrawal'.

Float is not a free option, and it is not a gamble on nothing. Two consequences follow from the bulletin that people miss. First, an upgraded Float candidate cannot simply walk into the new college: they need a relieving letter generated online from the earlier institute before joining the next one. Second, once upgraded, the Round 1 seat is cancelled immediately and re-allotted to somebody else - there is no going back to it.

How to choose between them

Ask one question: is there a realistic seat in a later round that you would take over this one? Not a dream seat - a seat that appeared in last year's closing lists at a rank close to yours. If yes, Float. If the answer is no, Freeze and stop reading the seat matrix.

Float is the right call when

Your allotted seat is in a branch or city you would trade for a realistic upgrade.

You have not yet seen your state's Round 1 result, and a state seat would beat this one.

You are holding a diploma seat and would take the same subject as a degree.

You are in a deemed university at full fee and would take a government seat in any clinical branch.

Freeze is the right call when

The seat is the branch you wanted and the fee and bond are ones you can live with.

You cannot risk the deposit - Rs 2,00,000 on a deemed seat is not a rounding error.

You have a bond or service obligation that only makes sense at this college.

The realistic upgrade is a move sideways to a similar college, which is not worth a forfeited deposit.

One-time document upload applies to both categories. Whether you Freeze or Float, you must upload clear scanned copies of your documents to MCC's portal within the reporting window - the bulletin advises

within two to three days of the final allotment, so that a discrepancy query from the college still leaves you time to fix it. The upload is done once and covers all rounds.

Three candidates, three right answers

The decision is easier when you see it applied. These are composite situations, not real candidates - but the reasoning is the reasoning you will use.

Holding a diploma seat in a state college, and would take the same subject as a degree

Float. The seat you hold is close in value to the upgrade you want, the deposit is Rs 25,000, and the downside is bounded: if you are upgraded you join the new seat, and if you are not, you keep the one you have. The risk is concentrated in one place - you must actually join the upgraded seat, because not joining it forfeits the deposit.

Holding a deemed university seat at a market fee, and would take any government clinical seat

Float, but only if you can survive the fee if no upgrade comes. The deposit at stake here is Rs 2,00,000, not Rs 25,000. If the family finances depend on the deposit coming back, Freeze - a Rs 2 lakh forfeiture is a worse outcome than three years in a deemed college you can afford.

Unallotted after Round 1, and your state result is still pending

This is not a Freeze or Float question at all - you have nothing to freeze. Fill a long, honest list in Round 2, and treat your state result as the event that decides whether you resign or keep what AIQ gives you. The clock on that decision is the state joining deadline, which for Round 1 is 10 November.

One more thing about Float that nobody warns you about. Floating means your documents are verified online, without you present. The nodal officer is looking at a scan, and a scan that is unclear reads as a document that is not there. If you are floating, re-photograph every certificate in daylight, at full resolution, flat on a table - and upload the best version you have, not the one you took at midnight.

PART 5

Free exit, then forfeiture

The rules that decide what it costs to change your mind - and the AIQ-or-state trap.

Round 1 is free. Round 2 costs you the deposit. Round 3 costs you the seat.

MCC's own flow chart for the counselling scheme states it in three lines: Round 1 exit is free, Round 2 exit is with forfeiture, and in Round 3 there is no resignation at all. Everything below follows from that.

If you hold a seat and want out	What happens	What you lose
Resign a Round 1 AIQ seat before the deadline	Free exit; you remain eligible for later rounds	Nothing but the seat
Resign a Round 2 AIQ seat	Exit with forfeiture; you can still enter Round 3 with fresh payment	The security deposit
Resign a Round 3 seat	Not permitted	You keep the seat
Simply not join a Round 2 or later seat	Deposit forfeited; treated as an exit with forfeiture	The security deposit
Not join a Round 3 seat	Deposit forfeited and no further rounds	The deposit and the cycle

Sources: MCC Information Bulletin 2026, Chapter 3 (resignation and surrender), Chapter 14 flow charts, FAQ 46.

Resigning is not the same as disappearing. A Freeze candidate resigns by physically reporting at the allotted institute and submitting the resignation there within MCC's window. A Float candidate resigns online: log in, choose 'Resignation / Surrender', attach the supporting documents, submit. An offline resignation, or a letter to the college, is not accepted - and the bulletin warns colleges that offline admissions and resignations may be treated as vacant seats with legal consequences for the college.

The trap: an AIQ seat and a state seat are not independent

You can register for MCC and for your state at the same time. You can even be allotted in both. What you cannot do is keep both. The moment you accept a state seat, the AIQ seat has to be surrendered - and the cost of that surrender depends entirely on which round you are in.

1. Both results are out and AIQ Round 1 is your only seat so far. Resign it freely and take the state seat.
2. You are holding an AIQ Round 1 seat and your state result comes in Round 2. If you want the state seat, you resign the AIQ seat - and if you are by then in AIQ Round 2, that resignation is with forfeiture.
3. You are holding an AIQ Round 2 seat. Resigning it for a state seat costs the deposit. Do the arithmetic before you do it: a Rs 25,000 deposit against the lifetime value of the branch and college you are moving to.
4. You are holding a state seat and are allotted in AIQ Round 3. You cannot resign a Round 3 AIQ seat - so the decision has to be made before you fill Round 3 choices.

The one-line rule

Decide what you actually want before Round 2 choice filling opens on 6 November. After that, every change of mind has a price, and the price rises with every round.

Also worth knowing: once you join an institute, that institute holds your original certificates. MCC has instructed colleges to retain originals precisely to stop seat blocking and multiple admissions, and to release them only on upgradation or on resignation within the specified timelines. So a college that is slow to release documents is not being difficult - it is following the rule, and your relieving letter has to be generated online before you can join the next place.

PART 6

Choice filling, done properly

Merit decides who gets asked. Your list decides what you are asked for.

The algorithm is simple, and it is not a matching market

MCC processes candidates in merit order. Each candidate is walked down their own list, in the order they wrote it, and gets the first seat on that list which is still free when their turn comes. That is the whole mechanism. Two consequences follow, and they are the two things people get wrong.

Consequence 1: order is everything, length is not a risk

Because the system stops at your first available choice, a long list can never hurt you. A choice placed at number 87 only matters if the first 86 are gone. There is no penalty for listing seats you will not get - only a penalty for not listing the seat you would have got.

Consequence 2: an unordered list is a random list

If you list colleges by prestige rather than by what you actually want, the algorithm will hand you the most prestigious one that is free at your rank - which may be a branch you do not want in a city you cannot reach. The list has to be in the order you would genuinely accept them, not the order you would brag about them.

And remember: you can fill fresh choices in every round. The bulletin says fresh choice filling is allowed in each round, so a Round 1 list is not a life sentence. What carries forward is the seat, not the list.

Building the list in three bands

The most useful structure is to sort every seat you would accept into three bands before you touch the portal. This keeps you honest about the bottom of your list, which is where seats are usually won or lost.

Band	What goes in it	How many	Why it matters
A - Reach	Branches and colleges you want but your rank probably will not reach	20 to 30	Free to include; occasionally a new seat or a category conversion lands here
B - Real	Seats that closed near your rank last year, in branches you would take	40 to 60	This is where you will almost certainly be allotted - order these with the most care
C - Floor	Seats you would accept rather than go seatless, including branches you are unsure about	20 to 40	The band that stops a stray vacancy scramble. Be honest, not proud

Aim for 100 or more total. There is no upper limit that hurts you, and every additional choice is another chance at a seat you would accept.

Three filters to apply before you rank anything

1. **Fee and bond first, prestige second.** A government seat with a Rs 40 lakh service bond is not the same product as a deemed seat at market fee with no bond. Part 9 gives you the worksheet.
2. **Recognised or permitted.** MCC allots on NMC-approved seats and states plainly that it does not distinguish between recognised and permitted seats in allotment. If recognition status matters to you - and for some career paths it does - check it on the college's own site or with the college, before the choice, not after.
3. **Distance and stipend.** MCC publishes college-supplied information on fees, bonds and stipend, and takes no responsibility for its accuracy. Treat it as a starting point and confirm with the college.

Then check the seat matrix for the round you are actually in. In Round 1 MCC shows only clear-cut vacancies. From Round 2 it shows two kinds: clear-cut vacancies (seats nobody took in the previous round) and virtual vacancies (seats held by candidates who have opted to upgrade). A virtual vacancy is not free - it

only becomes available if the current holder actually vacates or upgrades. Listing a page of virtual vacancies as your entire Round 2 strategy is how people end up with nothing.

Reading a seat matrix in ninety seconds

The seat matrix is a list of rows, one per college and course, with a count of seats in each category. Read it in this order and you will not miss the seats you are eligible for.

1. **Find your category column first, not the total.** A college with 40 seats and 3 in your category is a 3-seat college for you.
2. **Then check whether the seats are recognised or permitted.** The matrix may not say. If it matters, ask the college.
3. **Then check the quota.** AIQ, state quota, institutional quota, NRI and minority seats are separate lines and separate competitions - you can only list the ones you are eligible for.
4. **Then note whether the row is clear-cut or virtual.** From Round 2, virtual vacancies are held by candidates who have opted to upgrade; they only free up if those candidates actually move.
5. **Then compare with the previous round.** Seats that appeared out of nowhere are usually converted categories or newly approved seats - both are worth listing early.

What a matrix row looks like, and what it does not tell you

Illustrative shape only: College / Course / UR / EWS / OBC / SC / ST / PwD / total.

It does not tell you the closing rank, the fee, the bond, the stipend, or whether the seat will still be there when your turn comes. Those come from the college and from last year's lists, and neither is a promise.

The one thing the matrix does tell you reliably is which seats exist right now. That is enough to build a list from.

Twelve ways a choice list fails

Every one of these is a real failure mode, and every one is avoidable in under five minutes.

1. **You list 12 choices.** Twelve is not a strategy, it is a wish list. List a hundred.
2. **You rank by college reputation and ignore branch.** Three years in a branch you dislike is a long time to be proud of a name.
3. **You never check whether you are eligible for a quota you listed.** In-service, NRI, minority and institutional quotas have their own conditions, and an ineligible choice wastes a slot.
4. **You ignore the fee column.** Deemed seats can run into lakhs per year. Read the college's own fee notice.
5. **You forget the bond.** A Rs 50 lakh bond at a government college can be a bigger commitment than a private fee.
6. **You leave the list unlocked and assume it saved.** Check the print-out of your locked choices.
7. **You fill Round 2 choices without looking at the new seat matrix.** Round 2 includes virtual vacancies and freshly converted categories.
8. **You assume the Round 1 closing rank predicts Round 2.** It does not - the pool changes every round.
9. **You are not registered at all.** No registration, no allotment, no appeal. The window is five to ten days.
10. **You pay the fee but do not complete payment.** Only candidates who have paid the full fee become eligible for the further process.
11. **You skip the state portal because you are in AIQ.** Half the seats in the country are on that other portal.
12. **You ignore the document upload deadline.** A seat confirmed by allotment is cancelled by a missing certificate.

A five-minute check before you lock

Does every choice on this list name a seat I would actually join on Monday morning?

Is the order the order I would accept them, not the order I would describe them?

Is there at least one choice in the list I am almost certain to get?

Have I printed the locked list and saved the PDF?

PART 7

Round 3 and Stray Vacancy

Two more doors, with narrower eligibility than most people assume.

Round 3 is open to fewer people than Round 2

MCC lists three categories of candidate eligible for Round 3: those registering for the first time; those who registered but were not allotted a seat in Round 1 or Round 2; and those who exited with forfeiture in Round 2, who may participate with fresh payment of fees.

It also lists who is **not** eligible: candidates holding a seat in Round 1 or Round 2 of the AIQ who have not given willingness to upgrade in Round 3. In other words, holding a seat does not bar you - refusing to say whether you want to upgrade does.

The Round 3 rule that ends cycles

There is no resignation from a Round 3 seat. MCC's flow chart is explicit: candidates who do not join a Round 3 seat have their security deposit forfeited, and cannot participate in further rounds. If you fill Round 3 choices, you are saying you will take what you get.

Round 3 also carries the mandatory reporting step for everyone still floating. After the Round 3 provisional result, all Round 3 allottees and all Round 1 and Round 2 Float candidates who did not get upgraded must report. That is the point at which a Float seat becomes a real seat.

Stray Vacancy is the last door, and it is genuinely open

The Stray Vacancy Round has the widest eligibility of any round. Fresh candidates who never registered in Round 1, 2 or 3 can register and pay during it. So can every registered candidate who was not allotted a seat in any previous round. The one group that cannot use it is candidates who are holding a seat.

Round	Who can enter	Can you resign afterwards?
Round 1	Anyone registered and paid	Yes - free exit
Round 2	Anyone registered and paid, including those who exited Round 1	Yes - with forfeiture of deposit
Round 3	Fresh registrants; unallotted candidates; Round 2 exits with fresh payment	No
Stray Vacancy	Fresh registrants (with payment); anyone unallotted in all previous rounds	No

Source: MCC Information Bulletin 2026, FAQs 36, 37, 45, 46 and 50.

What actually turns up in stray vacancy. Seats that nobody joined, seats vacated late, and seats that were approved after the main rounds. The mix is unpredictable and the branch mix is skewed - but a stray vacancy seat is a seat. If you are unallotted at the end of Round 3, register for stray vacancy and fill a long, honest list. The alternative is a year.

And keep an eye on the calendar, not just the portal. Stray vacancy for AIQ runs 16 to 24 December with joining by 31 December; the state stray round runs 22 to 25 December with the same 31 December joining deadline. Both of those dates sit inside the holiday week, and MCC has told colleges to treat holidays as working days.

PART 8

The four doors compared

What each route costs you in money, years and obligations - before you rank it.

A government seat is not automatically the cheaper seat

The usual assumption is that government equals cheap and deemed equals expensive. In cash terms that is usually true. In obligation terms it can invert completely, because government seats in many states carry a service bond with a penalty in the tens of lakhs, and a deemed seat carries no service obligation at all.

	AIQ government college	State government college	Deemed university	DNB
Who counsels	MCC	State DME / CET Cell	MCC	MCC (open seats); NBE (in-service)
Tuition	Government fee, set by the state	Government fee, set by the state	Market fee, set by the institute	Set by the institute or hospital
Service bond	Usually yes - the state's bond applies to AIQ seats too, unless the state exempts AIQ	Almost always yes	Usually none	Varies by institute
Degree	MD / MS / Diploma from the university	MD / MS / Diploma from the university	MD / MS / Diploma from the deemed university	DNB from NBEMS
Reservation	Central policy: SC 15, ST 7.5, OBC 27, EWS 10, PwD 5	State policy - often different from central	Institute policy; NRI and minority quotas inside	None in private DNB institutes
Who collects admission fee	The college	The college	The college	NBE, after MCC allots
Refund of counselling deposit	MCC, after all rounds	State authority, per its rules	MCC, after all rounds	MCC; admission fee queries go to NBE

Sources: MCC Information Bulletin 2026, Chapters 6, 7 and 10, and FAQ 23 on fee and bond variance.

On the bond exemption point, be careful. Whether the state's service bond attaches to an AIQ seat in a state government college is a state-by-state decision, and some states have carved out AIQ candidates while others have not. The bulletin itself refuses to take a position: it says stipend, fee structure, bond amount and rural service conditions may vary from state to state and institute to institute, and that MCC is not responsible for them. So the bond question is answered by your state's brochure, not by MCC's.

DNB deserves a fair hearing

DNB is the route people treat as a fallback, and that reputation costs some candidates a good career. Three structural facts from the bulletin are worth knowing.

- MCC conducts DNB counselling for open seats, and it is domicile-free and All India in character - it follows a Supreme Court judgment of 26 May 2020.
- In-service DNB seats are not counselled by MCC at all; that is a separate process.
- After MCC allots a DNB seat, the admission fee is collected by NBE, and any refund query on that fee goes to NBE, not MCC.

What DNB gives you is hospital-based training, frequently in high-volume institutions, often with a stipend and no service bond. What it costs you is the recognition question in some employers' minds. That trade is yours to make - but make it with the fee, stipend and bond in front of you, not on the basis of a rumour from your internship batch group.

The one comparison worth doing on paper

For each of the two or three seats you are actually choosing between, write down: total course fee, monthly stipend, bond penalty and bond years, and the earliest date you could start working afterwards. Add the first three, subtract the second, and put the bond years in a separate column. The worksheet in Part 9 is built for this.

What each degree actually is

Four different qualifications sit inside this one counselling process, and the differences are structural rather than cosmetic.

Qualification	Usual length	Awarded by	What to check before ranking it
MD / MS	Three years	The university the college is affiliated to	Recognition status of the seat; bond; stipend
PG Diploma	Two years	The university the college is affiliated to	Whether the college offers the degree version of the same subject, and what upgrading would cost you
DNB	Three years	NBEMS	Hospital volume and caseload; stipend; whether the seat is in-service or open
MDS (dental)	Three years	The university or deemed university	Separate counselling stream - check the dental schedule, not the medical one

Course durations and awarding bodies are as set out in the counselling bulletin and the respective regulators' regulations. Confirm the specifics of any individual seat with the college.

The practical difference between a degree and a diploma is time. A diploma is a shorter course, and in the same subject it is not a substitute for the degree. If you are holding a diploma seat and a degree seat in the same subject is within reach in a later round, that is one of the clearest Float decisions in the whole cycle - a year of your career is worth more than a deposit.

PART 9

The bond, before you report

Four numbers, one worked example, and ten questions for the college office.

A bond is a promise with a price, and the price is not on the MCC portal

A PG service bond is an undertaking that you will serve the government for a set number of years after your degree, or pay a stated penalty. It is signed at joining, it is enforced by the state, and it is separate from the seat-leaving penalty you have already met through MCC's security deposit. Two different penalties, two different agreements, both real.

Read four numbers before you report, and read them from the state's own brochure for this year.

Number	Where it lives	Why it changes your decision
Years of service	State brochure, bond format annexure	Two years of rural or government service at a fixed salary is a real career cost, not a formality
Bond penalty	State brochure or the government order it cites	This is the amount you or your surety pay if you do not serve - and it can exceed the entire course fee
Seat-leaving penalty	State brochure and MCC's deposit rules	Separate from the bond; you can owe both
Surety requirement	Bond format annexure	Some states demand a surety bond plus a bank guarantee at joining - cash you must arrange in days

Why this book does not print a state-by-state bond table. Because the tables circulating online disagree with each other by crores. For Rajasthan alone, published figures in 2026 range from a flat Rs 25 lakh to a specialty-wise scale topping out at Rs 1.5 crore, depending on which order the author was reading. For Karnataka, one widely copied table says Rs 25 lakh over one year while another says Rs 50 lakh over three. Both cannot be right, and a wrong number in a decision this size is worse than no number. The rule that survives every year is: the current year's state instruction booklet and the bond format annexed to it are the only authority.

A worked example of how much the branch can cost

Rajasthan's medical education department issued an order in September 2025 fixing service bond amounts by branch for PG seats in government and RAJMES colleges. As reported consistently by the medical education press, the scale ran from about Rs 25 lakh for non-clinical subjects such as Anatomy, Physiology, Biochemistry and Community Medicine, through Rs 50 lakh for Anaesthesia, Pathology, Radiotherapy and similar, and Rs 1 crore for Orthopaedics, Paediatrics, General Surgery, Ophthalmology and Psychiatry, up to Rs 1.5 crore for General Medicine, Radiodiagnosis, Obstetrics and Gynaecology and Dermatology. Candidates also execute a surety bond at reporting - reported at Rs 10 lakh, part of it as a bank guarantee - against leaving the course midway.

Read that as a design lesson rather than a fixed fact. A bond scale that charges six times more for Dermatology than for Anatomy is telling you exactly what the state thinks those branches are worth to it. Before you rank a branch, find out whether your state prices bonds by branch, and if it does, look at the price of the branch you are about to choose. The same seat can be a Rs 25 lakh commitment or a Rs 1.5 crore one.

Bond figures are revised by government order, sometimes annually. Verify the current scale in your state's 2026-27 counselling brochure before you sign anything.

Ten questions to ask the college before you report

Ask these on the phone, in this order, and write the answers down with the name of whoever gave them. Ten minutes of this is worth more than a week of forum reading.

1. What is the total course fee for three years, including hostel, and what is payable at joining?
2. Is there a service bond, for how many years, and what is the penalty amount in this year's order?
3. Is a surety bond or bank guarantee required at joining, and for how much?
4. Does the bond apply to my quota - AIQ, state, management or NRI - specifically?
5. What is the monthly stipend, and is it paid on time?
6. Is my seat recognised or permitted by NMC as of today?
7. What is the seat-leaving penalty if I resign, and what is refundable?
8. Which original documents will the college retain, and when are they released?
9. What is the exact last date and time to report, and who signs the joining report?
10. Is there a relieving-letter process for upgradation, and who issues it?

The bond and cost sheet - copy this into a note on your phone

College and branch: _____ Quota: _____

Total fee over the course: Rs _____ Payable at joining: Rs _____

Monthly stipend: Rs _____ Bond years: _____

Bond penalty: Rs _____ Surety / bank guarantee: Rs _____

Seat-leaving penalty: Rs _____

Net cash over three years (fee minus stipend): Rs _____

Years committed after the degree: _____

Verified from: _____ (document name and date)

One more number people forget: the stipend. A government PG stipend in the range of Rs 50,000 to Rs 1,20,000 a month, paid for three years, is Rs 18 lakh to Rs 43 lakh of income during the course. That single figure can outweigh a fee difference between two colleges - and it is the number most candidates never ask about before ranking.

Stipend amounts vary by state, by college and by year, and several states revised them in 2025 and 2026. Confirm the current figure with the college rather than from a table.

PART 10

Documents that cancel seats

The allotment is provisional. The originals are what make it real.

A confirmed allotment is cancelled by a missing certificate, not by a better rank

MCC is direct about this: the allotment made in any round is purely provisional, subject to physical verification of your documents by the allotted college. And the bulletin goes further - candidates without original documents are not allowed to take admission, and a certificate saying your originals are deposited with another institute is not accepted either. So the paperwork is not an afterthought. It is the admission.

This is the document set MCC lists for joining. Check every line against your file tonight.

#	Document	Notes
1	Allotment letter issued by MCC	Essential - download from the MCC portal after the final result
2	NEET-PG admit card issued by NBE	Essential
3	NEET-PG result / rank letter issued by NBE	Essential
4	MBBS mark sheets - 1st, 2nd and 3rd professional	All three years
5	MBBS degree certificate or provisional certificate	Essential
6	Internship completion certificate, or a certificate from the head of institution that you will complete it by 30 September 2026	Essential - the cut-off for this cycle
7	Permanent or provisional registration certificate from a State Medical Council	Provisional accepted only if you are still an intern completing by 30 September 2026
8	10th class certificate or birth certificate as proof of date of birth	Essential
9	Photo ID - driving licence, voter ID, passport or Aadhaar	One of these
10	SC / ST certificate in the prescribed format	If applicable - English or Hindi, sub-caste clearly mentioned
11	OBC Non-Creamy-Layer certificate in the prescribed format	If applicable - sub-caste must match the central list; income basis is FY ending 31 March 2026
12	EWS certificate in the central format	If applicable - income and asset basis is FY ending 31 March 2026
13	PwD eligibility certificate from a designated Medical Assessment Board	Only boards on MCC's list; no other hospital or board is accepted
14	NRI / OCI documents in original	Same set you uploaded on the MCC portal

Source: MCC Information Bulletin 2026, Chapter 12 (Admission) and FAQ 6.

The five certificate traps

Each of these has cancelled a real seat in a real counselling cycle. None of them is about merit.

1. A regional-language certificate without certification
Certificates must be in English or Hindi. If yours is in another language, the translation must be certified by a gazetted officer. An uncertified translation is treated as no certificate.

2. An OBC certificate that does not match the central list
For AIQ, the sub-caste has to tally with the central list of OBCs, and you must be outside the creamy layer. A state-list OBC certificate is not automatically valid for a central quota seat. For Maharashtra's own counselling, the reverse applies - EWS must be in state format and a central-format EWS certificate is rejected. Read which format your counselling authority wants.

3. A PwD certificate from the wrong board
Only a designated Medical Assessment Board can issue the eligibility certificate, against the 21 benchmark disabilities under the RPwD Act 2016. A certificate from any other hospital or board is not entertained, however genuine the disability.

4. Originals already deposited elsewhere
If your originals are sitting in another college or university, MCC will not accept an undertaking in their place. Get them released before your reporting window, or you will be turned away at the counter.

5. A blurred scan in a Float candidature
Float candidates never visit the college, so the nodal officer verifies uploaded scans only. Blurred copies, incorrect certificates, missing documents and category mismatches are all flagged, and a query resolution window is your only chance to fix them. Photograph documents flat, in daylight, at full resolution - not on a bed at midnight.

Two small things that save a day. Keep two physical sets of everything - one for the college and one for yourself - and a single PDF of the whole set on your phone and in cloud storage. And check the spelling of your name across the NEET application, the admit card and your degree. If they differ, carry an affidavit or undertaking that ties the documents to the same person, as the bulletin advises.

The forty-eight hours after an allotment

An allotment gives you a short, specific sequence of actions. Do them in this order and nothing gets lost.

When	What you do	Why it matters
The hour it is declared	Download the allotment letter and the provisional result; screenshot the seat, college, course and category	The letter is an essential document at joining, and screenshots settle arguments
The same day	Decide Freeze or Float, on paper, using Worksheet 2 if you are holding another seat	The choice drives everything that follows - travel, documents, or an online joining
Within 2-3 days	Upload every document to the MCC portal, in clear scans	The bulletin advises 2-3 days so a discrepancy query still leaves time to answer it
Freeze: before the joining deadline	Travel with originals, complete verification, pay the college fee, get the joining acknowledged	Admission is confirmed only when the college verifies and accepts you
Float: before the joining deadline	Complete online joining, generate the provisional confirmation, watch for a discrepancy query	No physical visit, but a query unanswered is a cancelled seat
Throughout	Keep every receipt, screenshot and email in one folder	Refunds, relieving letters and disputes all run on evidence

If a discrepancy query arrives, answer it the same day. The document verification committee at the institute raises queries on blurred copies, incorrect certificates, category mismatches and missing documents, and gives you a correction window inside the reporting schedule. That window is measured in hours, not weeks. Float candidates who check their portal once at the start and once at the end are the ones who lose seats.

PART 11

State counselling

Half the PG seats in India are on a portal that is not MCC's.

If you only register with MCC, you have entered half the competition

Fifty per cent of PG seats in state government colleges are state quota, and 100% of seats in private non-deemed colleges in a state are filled through that state's counselling. MCC says plainly that it cannot guide candidates on state or private college seats, and that you must approach the state government or its admission authority. NBEMS adds that the final merit list and the category-wise merit lists for state quota seats are prepared by the states themselves.

So the state process is not a backup. For many candidates it is the main event, and it runs on its own rules, its own fees and its own document formats.

What is genuinely different about the state process

Eligibility is yours to check. Domicile rules, whether you must have done MBBS in the state, whether outside-state candidates can take private-college seats, and how in-service candidates are treated are all state decisions.

Fees and deposits are different. Maharashtra's 2026 notice, for example, sets a non-refundable registration fee of Rs 3,000 plus a security deposit as applicable, and it tells candidates to verify quota-wise fees before filling choices.

Verification can be physical. Karnataka's 2026 process required offline document verification at the KEA office in Bengaluru by slot - not an upload.

Certificate formats can differ. Maharashtra accepts only state-format EWS certificates for its own counselling.

The calendar is the state's. MCC's schedule sets the outer boundary for each round; the state sets the dates inside it.

Register on both, in the first week. The most common avoidable disaster in this cycle is a candidate who spends three weeks on MCC and discovers, after the state registration has closed, that their rank was far better in the state list.

A worked state timeline, so you know what to expect

Maharashtra's State CET Cell published Notice No. 01 on 16 October 2026 for state quota PG admissions 2026-27. It is a useful template because it shows how compressed a state round is.

Step	Date
Information brochure published	16 Oct 2026
Online registration	17 - 23 Oct 2026, 11:59 pm
Registration fee and security deposit payment	17 - 24 Oct 2026, 5:00 pm
Upload of scanned original documents	17 - 24 Oct 2026, 11:59 pm
Online document verification	18 - 27 Oct 2026
Provisional merit list	28 Oct 2026
Grievances on the merit list	29 - 30 Oct 2026
Final merit list and CAP Round 1 seat matrix	1 Nov 2026
CAP Round 1 preference filling	2 - 4 Nov 2026
CAP Round 1 selection list	5 Nov 2026
Physical joining with originals and fees	6 - 10 Nov 2026

Source: State CET Cell, Maharashtra, Notice No. 01 dated 16 October 2026.

Notice the shape of it: registration closes in six days, verification happens while you are still filling forms, the merit list is provisional for two days, and the gap between the selection list and the joining deadline is four days. A state round is not a leisurely process, and it is not a process you can join halfway.

Finding your state's process in two minutes

Every state and UT has a named authority and a portal. The authority names below are the ones that publish PG counselling notices; the portal names are as published by those authorities. If a link has moved, search the authority name - state portals are rebuilt most years.

State / UT	Authority	Portal
Maharashtra	State Common Entrance Test Cell	mahacet.org (PG medical portal)
Uttar Pradesh	Directorate General of Medical Education and Training	upneet.gov.in
Karnataka	Karnataka Examinations Authority	cetonline.karnataka.gov.in
Tamil Nadu	Directorate of Medical Education, Selection Committee	tnmedicalselection.net
Kerala	Commissioner for Entrance Examinations	cee.kerala.gov.in
Gujarat	Admission Committee for Professional Post-Graduate Medical Educational Courses	medadmgujarat.org
Madhya Pradesh	Directorate of Medical Education	dme.mponline.gov.in
West Bengal	West Bengal Medical Counselling Committee	wbmcc.nic.in
Bihar	Bihar Combined Entrance Competitive Examination Board	bceceboard.bihar.gov.in
Telangana	Kaloji Narayana Rao University of Health Sciences	knruhs.telangana.gov.in
Andhra Pradesh	Dr NTR University of Health Sciences	apuhs-pgadmissions.aptonline.in
Rajasthan	Directorate of Medical Education	medicaleducation.rajasthan.gov.in
Punjab	Baba Farid University of Health Sciences	bfuhs.ac.in
Jharkhand	Jharkhand Combined Entrance Competitive Examination Board	jceceb.jharkhand.gov.in
Odisha	Directorate of Medical Education and Training	dmetodisha.in

For Delhi and the other UTs, and for the north-eastern states, start from your state health department's medical education page and follow the PG counselling notice. MCC's state counselling schedule PDF is also the fastest way to confirm the outer deadlines for every state at once.

The three questions to answer about your state before the window opens

Am I eligible for state quota seats at all - and on what basis (domicile, MBBS from a state college, parent's domicile)?

Does my state allow outside-state candidates into private college seats, and under which quota?

If I am an in-service candidate, does my department need to forward my application, and by when?

What state quota eligibility usually turns on

No two states write their eligibility rules the same way, but almost every rulebook is built from the same four bases. Find which ones apply to you before the window opens, because eligibility is checked after allotment, not before it.

Basis	What it usually means	What to check
Domicile	You or your parents are domiciled in the state, evidenced by a domicile certificate	The exact certificate format and the issuing authority
MBBS from a state college	You studied MBBS in the state, which is often enough on its own	Whether the rule is about the college or the university
In-service	You are already a government doctor and are applying with departmental permission	Whether a service bond already applies to you and how it interacts with the new one
Open / private seats	Some private college seats are open to outside-state candidates, usually at a different fee	Whether outside-state candidates are limited to a specific quota, as Maharashtra does

Maharashtra's 2026 notice is a useful illustration of how specific these rules get: candidates who passed MBBS outside Maharashtra, and foreign medical graduates, are eligible only for institute-quota seats of private colleges. That single line changes the entire strategy for a candidate who studied elsewhere.

Eligibility is checked after allotment. A state will allot you a seat and then cancel it if the certificate does not hold up - the same pattern as MCC. So the certificate is not paperwork to collect later; it is the condition on which the seat exists.

PART 12

If this cycle gives you nothing

Three real routes out, and one honest conversation about the fourth.

INI-CET is still live while this counselling runs

The Institutes of National Importance run their own entrance test for AIIMS (all campuses), JIPMER Puducherry, PGIMER Chandigarh, NIMHANS Bengaluru and SCTIMST Thiruvananthapuram. It is a completely separate exam from NEET-PG, and for the January 2027 session the key dates have already been published.

INI-CET January 2027	Detail
Exam date	1 November 2026
Result expected	7 November 2026
Courses start	1 January 2027
Last date of admission	28 February 2027
Format	Computer-based test, 200 questions, 180 minutes, four timed parts of 50 questions each
Marking	Plus one for correct, minus one-third for incorrect
Qualifying percentile	50th for UR, EWS, sponsored and foreign national candidates; 45th for OBC, SC, ST, PwBD
Application fee	Rs 4,000 (general, OBC-NCL, OCI, sponsored); Rs 3,200 (SC, ST, EWS); nil for PwBD
Internship cut-off	Completed by 31 January 2027

Source: AIIMS INI-CET January 2027 Prospectus Part A, published 16 September 2026.

Registration for this session closed on 13 October 2026, so if you did not apply, the January 2027 route is not open to you - the July 2027 session is. If you did apply, the result lands on 7 November, right in the middle of AIQ Round 2, and the seat allocation follows separately. Read the Part B prospectus of each institute before you make any decision, because institute-specific rules on holding another PG seat, stipend, bond and resignation penalties live there and differ from institute to institute.

Do not assume the two systems talk to each other. AIQ counselling and INI-CET seat allocation are run by different bodies with different rulebooks. If you are holding an AIQ seat and are allocated an INI seat, the consequences - including whether you must resign the AIQ seat and what that costs in this round - come from both rulebooks. Ask both authorities in writing before you act.

If you are an intern aiming at 2027, the calendar starts now

The 2027 cycle will look like this one: the bulletin and registration around July, the exam in late August, the result in late September, and MCC counselling from early October. Three things you can do in the meantime that actually move your rank.

1. **Fix your internship paperwork now.** The internship completion cut-off for this cycle was 30 September 2026. Know your own completion date, get the certificate issued on time, and keep your State Medical Council registration current - the bulletin treats a lapsed registration as an essential-document failure.
2. **Build your document file before you need it.** Caste, EWS and OBC-NCL certificates have financial-year validity. An OBC-NCL certificate issued for the wrong financial year is a cancelled seat. Start the renewal in the January before your cycle, not in September.
3. **Learn the counselling mechanics this year, while it is free.** Read your state's 2026 brochure and MCC's 2026 bulletin now. When your turn comes you will be making decisions in a five-day window, and the people who do that well are the ones who read the rules a year early.

The honest version of the fourth route
A repeat year is a legitimate choice and a bad default. Take it if your rank was held back by something you can actually change - a subject you did not revise, an exam-day problem, a health issue - and if you can name the specific gap you will close. Do not take it because the branch you were offered felt unglamorous. A PG degree in a branch you will practise for thirty years beats a rank you will remember for two.

The ten days after the last round

The cycle does not end when the last seat is allotted. Three things are still live in the first fortnight of January, and two of them are about money you are owed.

1. **Watch for MCC's completion notice.** Refunds start only after MCC announces that counselling is complete. The custodian then has 15 days to initiate and 30 days to complete. If you have heard nothing by the middle of February, write to financemcc@lifecarehll.com with your registration number and payment reference.
2. **Keep the card or account open.** A refund to a closed card fails, and recovering it means manual reconciliation and a lot of correspondence. This is the single most common refund problem and the easiest to avoid.
3. **Collect your originals.** If you joined a college and then left, your certificates come back only when the college processes the resignation or upgradation. Chase the relieving letter in writing, and keep a copy of everything you submitted.
4. **If you have no seat, register for stray vacancy the moment it opens.** Fresh registration is allowed in that round with payment, and it is the last door before the next cycle.
5. **Write down what happened this year.** Which round you were allotted in, what your list looked like, what your state rank was, what the fees and bonds were. If you are back here next October, that note will be worth more than any forum post.

And if you are starting again, start earlier than feels necessary. The candidates who do well in this process are not the ones with the best ranks - they are the ones who knew the rules in September instead of learning them in November.

PART 13

Worksheets

Print these, or copy them into a note. They take twenty minutes and save a cycle.

Worksheet 1: the choice-order planner

Fill the bands first, then number the list. Do not open the portal until this page is finished.

Band	College	Branch	Fee per year	Bond (years / Rs)	Rank in my list

Rules for filling it: every row must be a seat you would join. If you would not join it, cross it out now rather than at 2 am on the last night of choice filling.

Worksheet 2: comparing two allotments

Use this the moment you are holding one seat and are offered another. It is the only decision that really matters in Rounds 2 and 3.

Question	Seat A	Seat B
College and branch		
Total fee over the course		
Stipend per month		
Net cash (fee minus stipend)		
Bond years		
Bond penalty		
Seat-leaving penalty if I resign now		
Recognised or permitted		
Distance from family		
Would I still choose it in year three?		

Two notes before you use this. The order matters more than the dates - registration and documents first, because everything else depends on them being done. And do not treat any row as optional because it looks like paperwork: the rows in this table are the ones that have cost people seats, not time.

Worksheet 3: the 30-day action plan

When	Do this	Why
Today	Register on MCC and on your state portal, or confirm both registrations are complete and paid	No registration, no allotment - and windows do not reopen for you
Today	Download the NEET-PG scorecard and rank letter to your phone and email	Every portal asks for them; they expire after six months
Day 1-2	Build the document file: two physical sets plus one PDF	A missing original cancels an allotment
Day 2-3	Check every certificate's format, language and financial year	OBC, EWS and PwD certificates fail on format more often than on merit
Day 3-4	Call your top five colleges and ask the ten questions in Part 9	Fee, bond and stipend change the ranking
Day 4-5	Complete Worksheet 1, all three bands	An unordered list is a random list
Day 5	Confirm your state's eligibility rules for your quota	Domicile and in-service rules vary by state
Before each round opens	Re-read the seat matrix and revise the list	Virtual vacancies and category conversions change the board every round
Before locking	Print the locked choice list and save the PDF	It is your only record of what you asked for
After allotment	Decide Freeze or Float within the reporting window	The default is not neutral - silence costs you the round
At joining	Carry originals, keep the receipt, note who verified what	The college holds your originals until you upgrade or resign
After all rounds	Keep your bank account or card active until the deposit lands	A closed account means a failed refund

PART 14

Quick answers

The questions that arrive in the last week, answered from the bulletin.

Can I be in AIQ and state counselling at the same time?
Yes. Register and pay on both portals. You cannot hold both seats - accepting a state seat means surrendering the AIQ seat, and the cost of that surrender depends on the round you are in.

Do I have to travel to the college if I want to upgrade?
No. That is the 2026 change. Float candidates submit willingness online and upload documents; the institute's nodal officer verifies them online. Only Freeze candidates travel, because they are joining.

If I get upgraded, do I need anything from the old college?
Yes - a relieving letter generated online from the Round 1 institute, before you can join the new one. The old seat is cancelled the moment you are upgraded.

I did not get a seat in Round 1. What do I do?
You remain eligible for Round 2. Fill fresh choices in the new round's window, and check the new seat matrix - it includes seats released by upgraders.

I was allotted in Round 1 and did not join. Am I out?
No. Round 1 is a free exit. You keep your deposit and remain eligible for later rounds.

I was allotted in Round 2 and did not join. Am I out?
You lose the security deposit, but you can still participate in Round 3 with fresh payment of fees.

Can I resign a Round 3 seat?
No. There is no resignation from Round 3, and not joining forfeits the deposit and ends your participation.

I never registered at all. Is there any way in?
Yes - fresh registration is allowed in the Stray Vacancy Round, with payment. That is the last door of the cycle.

What happens to my security deposit if I get no seat at all?
It is refunded. Refunds start after all rounds end: MCC notifies completion, the custodian initiates within 15 days and completes within 30 days, and the bank takes another 2 to 15 days.

Can the deposit go to a different account?
No. It goes back only to the card or account you paid from, and not to an NRI account. Keep it open until the refund lands.

My choices were not locked. What happened?
The server locked whatever you had saved when the window closed. If you had saved nothing, you went into allotment with nothing.

Does MCC decide my fee and bond?
No. MCC says explicitly that it does not fix fees and is not responsible for bond, stipend or service conditions, and that this information is supplied by the colleges. Confirm with the college and the state brochure.

What if my certificate is in Marathi or Tamil?
Certificates must be in English or Hindi. The translation must be certified by a gazetted officer.

I am an OCI cardholder. Am I eligible?
Per the Supreme Court order of 3 February 2023 as applied by MCC, OCI cardholders are treated at par with Indian citizens for NEET-PG 2026 counselling and are eligible for UR and NRI seats. Read Chapter 4 and Chapter 7 of the bulletin for the document set.

Can I take a seat in one round and still be considered in the next?
Yes - that is exactly what Float is for. Submit willingness for upgradation online, keep the current seat until you are upgraded, and join the new seat if you are. If you are not upgraded, the earlier seat is retained.

I am holding an AIQ seat and my state allotment is better. What do I do?
Resign the AIQ seat - online if you were a Float candidate, physically at the institute if you were a Freeze candidate - and then join the state seat. The cost depends on the round: free in Round 1, forfeiture in Round 2, not permitted in Round 3.

Does a long choice list reduce my chances?
No. The system moves down your list and stops at the first available seat. A long list can only help you.

Will I get the same seat in Round 2 that I had in Round 1?
Only if nobody above you takes it and you did not opt to upgrade. A Float candidate who is upgraded loses the old seat immediately.

Is the stipend guaranteed?
No. Stipend is set by the state or institute, varies by college, and is not something MCC controls or guarantees. Ask the college directly, in writing if you can.

Who do I call when the portal breaks?
MCC's PG counselling helpline is 1800 1027637 and 0120-4073500. Refund queries go to financemcc@lifecarehll.com; everything else to callcentremcc@lifecarehll.com.

The one-page card

Screenshot this. It is the whole book, compressed.

The four doors	Who runs it
50% All India Quota	MCC
State quota and private colleges	Your state's DME / CET Cell
Deemed universities (100%)	MCC
DNB (100%, open seats)	MCC; in-service DNB is separate

The calendar	AIQ	State
Round 1	12-24 Oct | join 2 Nov	21 Oct-2 Nov | join 10 Nov
Round 2	6-14 Nov | join 23 Nov	14-23 Nov | join 30 Nov
Round 3	26 Nov-4 Dec | join 12 Dec	4-12 Dec | join 18 Dec
Stray Vacancy	16-24 Dec | join 31 Dec	22-25 Dec | join 31 Dec
Session begins	20 Nov 2026	20 Nov 2026

The money	Registration fee	Deposit
AIQ - UR / EWS	Rs 1,000	Rs 25,000
AIQ - SC / ST / OBC / PwD	Rs 500	Rs 10,000
Deemed - all categories	Rs 5,000	Rs 2,00,000

The five rules that decide most outcomes

Round 1 exit is free. Round 2 exit forfeits the deposit. Round 3 has no exit.

Freeze means join physically and stop. Float means stay in the race without travelling.

Choices auto-lock at the deadline - save and print them.

An allotment is provisional until the college verifies your originals.

The state portal is a second, independent competition. Register on both.

PART 15

Sources

Everything in this book traces back to one of these. Check the live version before you act.

Primary documents used

Document	What it settles
MCC, NEET-PG (MD/MS/DNB) Counselling 2026 - Information Bulletin and Counselling Scheme	Fees, deposits, forfeiture, refunds, Freeze and Float, documents, eligibility, conversion algorithm, DNB, deemed universities, NRI, PwD
MCC, 'NEET-PG Schedule 2026 - All India Quota / Deemed / Central / State Quota', 8 October 2026	Round windows and joining dates for both tracks; academic session start
MCC, tentative schedule for 50% AIQ and 100% deemed / central universities / AFMS, PG 2026	Step-by-step dates inside Round 1, including choice locking
NBEMS notice declaring NEET-PG 2026 results, 24 September 2026	Candidates appeared, result date, qualifying cut-offs, scorecard validity
AIIMS, INI-CET January 2027 Prospectus Part A, published 16 September 2026	INI-CET dates, format, fees, percentiles, internship cut-off
State CET Cell, Maharashtra, Notice No. 01 dated 16 October 2026	A worked state-level timeline and state fee structure
State DME / counselling authority brochures for 2026-27	Bond years, bond penalty, surety requirements, domicile and quota rules

Where to check, in order

1. **mcc.nic.in** - the PG counselling section. The bulletin, the schedules and every notice are there, and they are revised without much warning.
2. **natboard.edu.in** - NEET-PG results, scorecards, notices. NBEMS is the exam authority, not the counselling authority.
3. **Your state's counselling portal** - listed in Part 11. The state brochure is the only authority on bond, domicile, in-service and state fees.
4. **The college's own website and office** - fee, stipend, bond, recognition status, and the exact reporting address. MCC tells you to do this and says it takes no responsibility for college-supplied data.
5. **aiimsexams.ac.in** - INI-CET prospectus parts A and B, and institute-specific rules.

A final word about being careful

This book is a guide to the rules, not legal or admission advice, and it is not affiliated with MCC, NBEMS, NMC, AIIMS or any state authority. Counselling rules change by notice, sometimes mid-round. Where this book and an official document disagree, the official document is right - and the official document is the one you should read on the morning of your decision.

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